

This topic will introduce the concept of project management, including the growing need for better project management with a particular focus on IT projects. You will explore examples of projects and the components that guarantee their success. Next, you will learn about the key elements of the project management framework, including project portfolio management. Finally, you will understand the role of project management and the profession.

You will read the content, watch videos, complete activities to test your understanding of this topic and participate in a workshop.

But before you begin, let's briefly discuss the growing need for better project management.



[← Discussion: Subject Q&A](#)

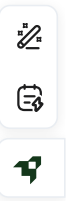
Jump to...

[Discuss: Why do we need better project management? →](#)

You are logged in as Hoang Thanh Truc Nguyen (Log out)

[Emergency information](#) [Child Safety](#) [Contacts](#) [Site map](#) [Accessibility](#) [Privacy](#) [Copyright and disclaimer](#)

© Copyright 2025 La Trobe University. All rights reserved. La Trobe University CRICOS Provider Code Number 00115M



Project management is a process that involves the use of specific skills, knowledge, tools and techniques to deliver a project within the given constraints to drive value for a business.

Let's watch the video below to explore project management in detail.



Watch

Watch this video "What is project management? [4.32 min]" for an overview of project management, including an introduction to the most popular project management methods and software tools.

What Is Project Management? Project Management Explained And Top Products



© 2020 by TechnologyAdvice. *What is project management?*

Projects involve various aspects, processes and stakeholders. To complete a project successfully, we need a project manager who is well versed in all the processes and can manage all aspects of the project. This requires a combination of skill sets. With the growth in the demand for project managers who can handle all aspects of a project, there is a gap in the talent pool available to fill these positions; read the report below to learn more about this gap.



Read

Read the [*Project management growth and talent gap: 2017–2027*](#) (PMI, 2017) report, which explores the gap in the project management talent pool and provides more information on career pathways for project managers.



Activity

Select each tab to learn more about project management basics.

▼ What is a project?

According to the Project Management Institute (as cited in Garg et al., 2022, p. 283), a project can be 'any temporary endeavour with a definite beginning and end'.

Projects share certain characteristics. They (Kerzner, 2017):

- have a specific objective to be completed within certain specifications
- have a defined life span with start and end dates
- are subject to financial constraints (if applicable)
- require human and nonhuman resources (e.g. money, people, equipment)
- are multifunctional (i.e. cut across several functional lines).



> The importance of project management

Project management tools

Project managers and team managers can use an array of project management tools, with these tools' capabilities including:

- team collaboration and communication
- project planning and scheduling
- resource allocation
- project documentation
- quality assurance.



Watch

Watch this video "Introducing project management tools [5.39 min]" to learn about project management tools, their use within organisations, their benefits and how to find the right ones for your team.

Introducing Project Management Tools



© 2022 by Wrike. *Introducing project management tools*



Read

Explore a list of project management tools by visiting [Project management tools](#) (ProjectManager, n.d.-a).

Project attributes

Table 1.1 explains the distinctive characteristics of a project in depth.

Table 1.1

Project attributes



Objectives	Every project is started with some objective or goal, namely time, budget, quality and quantity. You can initially define the objectives of the project as what actually needs to be achieved. Objectives are the key characteristics of the project where you will see the progress of the project, and time-to-time analysis will show you how much you have achieved.
Single entity	A project is one whole thing. This means that although different people contribute, they are still recognised as a single entity. Teams are often specifically assembled for a single project.
Life span	No project can be ceaseless and indefinite. Every project is invariably time-bound. At the time of planning, you will see the time phase of the project where the team can work independently on the project modules. Let's consider an example project that is divided into three modules: A, B and C. If the total time span of a project is 5 months, then you can set the time span for the modules independently; for example, A can be completed in 2 months, B can be completed in 2 months and C can be completed in 1 month to meet the total project's time span requirement.
Require funds	Every project needs funds to reach the endpoint. Without adequate funds, no project can be successfully implemented. Cost estimation is one of the essential factors for any organisation. So, calculating in advance the required funds for the project will be very impactful.
Life cycle	Each project has a life cycle with different stages like start, growth, maturity and decay. A project has to pass through different stages to get itself completed. Let's consider an example where the project is related to software development; the software development life cycle (SDLC) will be the life cycle of the project and will include many stages, such as planning, defining, designing, building, testing, deployment and so on.
Team spirit	Team spirit is required to get the project completed because the project constitutes different members having different characteristics and from various disciplines. But to achieve a common goal, harmony, missionary zeal and team spirit are necessary.



Risk and uncertainty	Projects are generally based on forecasting. So, risk and uncertainty are always associated with projects. There will be a high degree of risk in projects that are not properly defined. Only the degree of control over risk and uncertainty varies with the project being conceived based on information available.
Directions	A project is always performed according to the directions given by the customers with regard to time, quality, quantity and so on. The convenience of the supply sides of economics (e.g. labour availability, ore resources, managerial talent) are all secondary concerns, with the primary concern being the customer requirement.
Uniqueness	Each project is unique in itself, with its own features. No two projects are the same, even if the type of organisation is the same. The uniqueness of the project can be measured by considering many factors, such as objectives, features of the project, application of the project and so on.
Flexibility	The terms change and project are deeply intertwined. A project sees many changes throughout its life span. These changes can make projects more dynamic and flexible.
Subcontracting	Subcontracting is a subset of nearly every project without which no project can be completed (unless it is a proprietary firm or tiny in nature). The more complex a project, the greater the extent of contracting. Every project needs the help of an outsider consultant, engineer or expert in that field.
Cost	If the quality of the project is to be changed there could be an impact on the cost of the project. The cost could increase if more resources are required to complete the project quicker.



Adapted from [Project Management | Characteristics of Project](#) © Geeks for Geeks, 2021

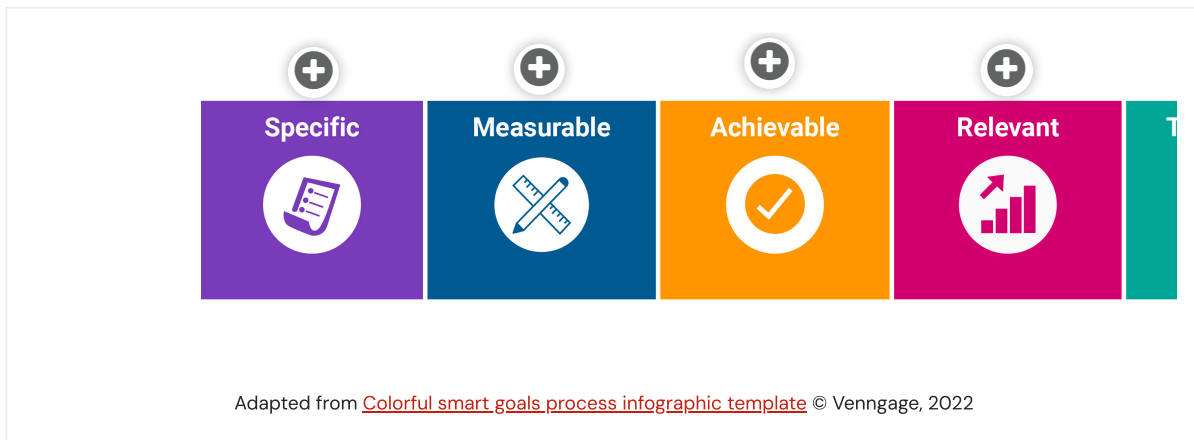
Smart goals

Clearly defined goals and objectives are the basis for a consensus on the definition of success and thus are essential for the delivery of a project. Business analysts should document them for subsequent works relying on them. A well-written goal or objective should be specific, measurable, achievable, realistic and timely. These criteria are summarised as the SMART model.



Activity

Select the (+) icons to learn more about SMART goals in project management.



Activity

Select each tab to learn about examples of SMART goals for project managers.

▼ Example 1

Adopt a work management tool (**specific**) that organizes at least 50 (**measurable**) incoming work requests per week (**attainable**) so that our team can streamline task assignment (relevant) within 30 days of receipt (**time-bound**).

(Wrike, n.d.-a, para. 17)

> Example 2

> Example 3

Project management framework

Successful project management requires the efficient allocation of resources and scheduling of activities in phases, focusing on specific objectives and outputs. To achieve project management excellence, managers can adopt repetitive processes or frameworks for their projects which have been used and tested in many projects. Such frameworks are also referred to as project management methodologies.

Read

Read the webpage [What is a project management framework?](#) (Wrike, n.d.-b), where you can explore project management framework in detail.

Project management examples

Let's explore IT project management with a real-world example.

Read

Read the article [Transforming an IT problem into business value: A case study of business and IT partnering to drive success](#) (Giambartolomei, 2016) to explore how different aspects of project management were successfully applied to an IT project to drive a business to success.

Discuss

Project attributes

In this discussion, you will solidify what you've learnt in this week's content so far.

1. **Reflect** on and answer the following questions:

- Can BUS5MIP be considered a project?
- What is the unique purpose of BUS5MIP?
- How long will the BUS5MIP project take?
- Is BUS5MIP developed using progressive stages?
- What resources are required for BUS5MIP?
- Is there any uncertainty in the BUS5MIP project?
- Who are the stakeholders?
- What are your expectations as the primary stakeholder for the BUS5MIP course?

2. **Post** your answers to the discussion board.

3. **Review** your classmates' posts. Is there anything in their experience that is new to you? Comment constructively on at least two posts.



← Discuss: Why do we need better project management?



Jump to...

Project success →

You are logged in as Hoang Thanh Truc Nguyen (Log out)

[Emergency information](#) [Child Safety](#) [Contacts](#) [Site map](#) [Accessibility](#) [Privacy](#) [Copyright and disclaimer](#)

© Copyright 2025 La Trobe University. All rights reserved. La Trobe University CRICOS Provider Code Number 00115M

Projects exist to create business value with deliverables. Project managers are assigned to manage the project resources — based on the project's nature, scope and constraints — to meet the performance goals. The definition of success for a project is crucial for project managers to understand; a firm knowledge of the drivers and criteria of project success and failure enables them to optimise the management of resources and deliver the projects as expected by the stakeholders.

Defining project management success criteria

Historically, the objective of project management was to control the company resources to meet a set of predefined expectations under budget and within time. Therefore time, budget/cost and scope have been accepted as the triple constraint triangle to define project success. More recently, practitioners have realised that these three criteria alone cannot sufficiently represent the various situations of projects. Therefore, more factors such as risk, business image/reputation and quality have been considered part of the criteria against which project success is measured.



Read

The following two sections of the webpage [The triple constraint: The project management triangle of scope, time, and cost](#) (Eby, 2022) look at the triple constraint triangle in project management, including its history, its current form and what it might look like in the future. These optional readings provide insight on the challenges involved in project management and how to overcome them.

- [What is the triple constraint triangle in project management?](#)
- [The past, present, and future of the project constraint triangle](#)

Evaluating project management success

After the project success is clearly defined, it is important to measure and evaluate the criteria throughout the project management life cycle to track the progress, identify issues, adapt to changes, coordinate team collaboration and ensure customer satisfaction.



Read

The article [Revisiting the definition of IT project success](#) (Cavarec, 2012), discusses the triple constraint as the criteria for evaluating project success and alternative models that define success criteria based on stakeholders' expectations.



Watch

Watch this video "5-4 evaluation of project success [6.54 min]" to understand the evaluation process of a project to gauge its success.

5-4 Evaluation of project success



© 2021 by Project Business. 5-4 evaluation of project success

[← Introduction to project management](#)

Jump to...

[Project portfolio management \(PPM\) →](#)

You are logged in as Hoang Thanh Truc Nguyen (Log out)

[Emergency information](#) [Child Safety](#) [Contacts](#) [Site map](#) [Accessibility](#) [Privacy](#) [Copyright and disclaimer](#)

© Copyright 2025 La Trobe University. All rights reserved. La Trobe University CRICOS Provider Code Number 00115M

Organisations have to manage an assortment of projects, programs and processes to align with strategic business goals, all using finite resources. Where the project management process focuses on managing the project the right way, project portfolio management (PPM) focuses on managing the right project at the right time (ProjectManager, n.d.-b).

PPM is generally the responsibility of portfolio managers or a project management office (PMO), and is carried out using business analysis methods (e.g. forecasting and budget review). Further, PPM is a continual process; its ongoing nature ensures the schedule and allocation of resources is optimised across all of the organisation's projects. This helps to keep risks and costs to a minimum, maximises stakeholder satisfaction and value to the business (ProjectManager, n.d.-b).



Watch

Watch this video "What is portfolio management vs. project management? [5.03 min]" to understand the differences between portfolio management and project management.

What is Portfolio Management vs. Project Management?



© 2014 by ProjectManager. *What is portfolio management vs. project management?*

Benefits of project portfolio management

Organisations will benefit from PPM if they need to manage multiple projects. Watch the video below to understand the benefits of PPM.



Watch

Watch this video "5 benefits in adopting project portfolio management — project management training [3.25 min]" to understand the five benefits of adopting project portfolio management.

5 Benefits in Adopting Project Portfolio Management - Project Management Training



© 2018 by ProjectManager. *5 benefits in adopting project portfolio management — project management training*

The five steps of project portfolio management

Table 1.2 shows five main steps in the project portfolio management process in project management.

Table 1.2

PMM



Identify the guiding objectives of the business	If you work for a grocery store, is their goal to provide the freshest food, the largest selection or the lowest prices? If the lowest prices are the priority, then projects to promote cost savings are much more important than projects to improve the food's quality.
Capture and research requests and ideas	Project ideas could come from anywhere at any time. It's important to have a formalised intake process to capture these ideas so they can be tracked and evaluated. This may be as simple as a spreadsheet maintained by the portfolio manager, or it could be an online database where anyone in the company can enter ideas as they think of them.
Select the best projects	Once ideas are captured, portfolio managers must go through a standard process to evaluate and select the projects that will move forward. This requires more than just ensuring they are aligned with the company objectives, such as: • How much will it cost? • How long will it take? • What is the return on this project? (What benefit will it provide?) • Are the resources available? • What are the risks associated with this project? Since decisions are being made on multiple projects at once, this can become even more complex. A common way to simplify the project portfolio management process, and remove any bias, is to create a simple list of criteria that each project is measured and scored against, such as return on investment (ROI), which is a common ranking factor.
Validate portfolio feasibility and initiate projects	Once a determination has been made on which projects to move forward, it's important to validate the portfolio as a whole. This can include making sure the mix of projects chosen isn't too large, too risky, too expensive or too interdependent. The portfolio should be properly balanced and aligned with business goals. For example, if three of your projects forecast testing in January, and you only have one test lab, this is an issue. Also, if two projects are interrelated and a delay in one will push out the other, you may want to reconsider starting them both simultaneously. Once the portfolio is validated, project managers can be assigned and the projects initiated.



Manage and monitor the portfolio	Projects change and evolve over time, and new ideas may be added to the list of potential projects. This is why it's important to continually manage both the ongoing portfolio execution and the intake process. Managing and monitoring the portfolio may include: • working with project managers to monitor the performance of projects • identifying and resolving conflicts between projects • making changes to the portfolio as needed, including putting projects on hold, cancelling projects and adding in new projects • ensuring projects are still aligned with the business objectives.
---	---



Adapted from [What is Project Portfolio Management \(PPM\)?](#) © Wrike, n.d.

 Read

The article [What is effectiveness in project portfolio management?](#) (Patanakul et al., 2012) explores project portfolio management effectiveness from a real-life business setting to propose a definition.

Best tools for PPM

There are some tools that have been used successfully by project managers and have proven to be effective and efficient. You can explore these tools below.

 Resources

Read the article [10 best PPM tools for 2022: Comparison and expert reviews](#) (Aston, 2022) to explore some market-leading PPM tools.

[← Project success](#)

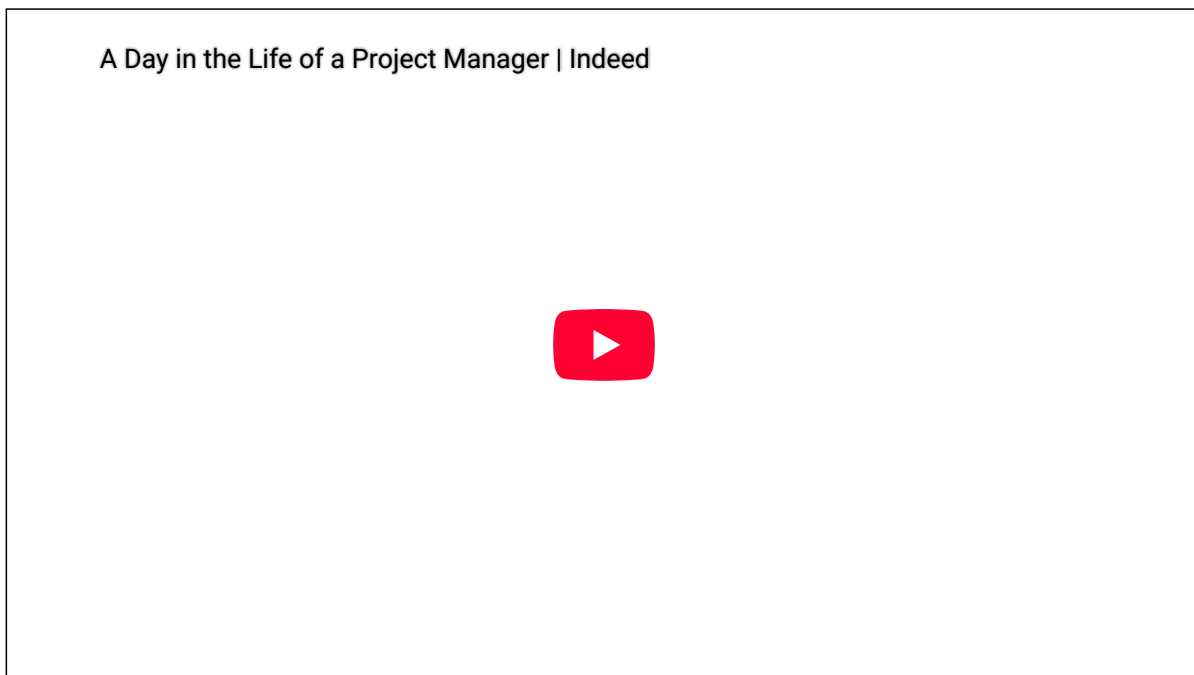
Jump to...

[The role of project management and the profession →](#)

As a project manager, you will be entrusted with various responsibilities. Therefore, it is important to understand the full scope of your duties to be able to successfully complete and execute a project. Watch the video below to understand what a day in the life of a project manager looks like and the profession in general.

Watch

Watch this video "A day in the life of a project manager [8.30 min]" to learn about the daily life of a project manager, including work hours, work environment, job duties, and the skills and education needed to be a successful project manager.



© 2022 by Indeed. *A day in the life of a project manager*

Skills and competencies

As a project manager, it is important to understand the skills you need to possess to be successful in your career. Some of the key skills required to be a successful project manager are listed below.

Activity

Select the (+) icons to learn more about key project management skills.



Adapted from [8 key project management skills to become successful](#) © ProjectCubicle, 2022



Read

The article [What do all successful project managers have in common?](#) (Ajia, 2022) discusses the characteristics of a successful project leader.

Careers for project managers

Project managers have a great career trajectory. As a project manager, you will manage a diverse set of activities and acquire a wide range of skills that people in some other occupations do not. You will interact with various partners and manage stakeholders from different parts of an organisation, which will set you up for positions in senior leadership. Watch the video below to learn the various career pathways for project managers.



Watch

Watch this video "Project manager career path: from junior PM to CEO [9.07 min]" to learn about the project manager career path from junior PM to CEO.

Project Manager Career Path: From Junior PM to CEO



© 2019 by IT Project Managers. *Project manager career path: from junior PM to CEO*

Ethics in project management

Ethics play an important role in project management. As a decision maker, you have to take some important decisions that may or may not be in favour of some stakeholders. At every point, your primary responsibility should be towards successful completion of the project within ethical considerations. So, what are these ethical considerations?

“

A project leader is invited to be ready for the challenges of realizing a sustainable professional future. This can be achieved through meeting the standards set for at the individual level, and always benchmark decisions to be taken to those standards. Compassion, Ethics and Hard Work are the foundation and the essence that will fuel the project manager's journey toward achieving their role.

”

(Gretta Kelzi, n.d.)



Resources

Learn about PMI's [code of ethics and professional conduct](#) by visiting its webpage [Ethics considerations for the project manager in professional services](#) (Schweriner, 2007).

← [Project portfolio management \(PPM\)](#)

Jump to...

[Workshop 1](#) →

You are logged in as Hoang Thanh Truc Nguyen (Log out)

[Emergency information](#) [Child Safety](#) [Contacts](#) [Site map](#) [Accessibility](#) [Privacy](#) [Copyright and disclaimer](#)

© Copyright 2025 La Trobe University. All rights reserved. La Trobe University CRICOS Provider Code Number 00115M

